HIJMS MIKASA

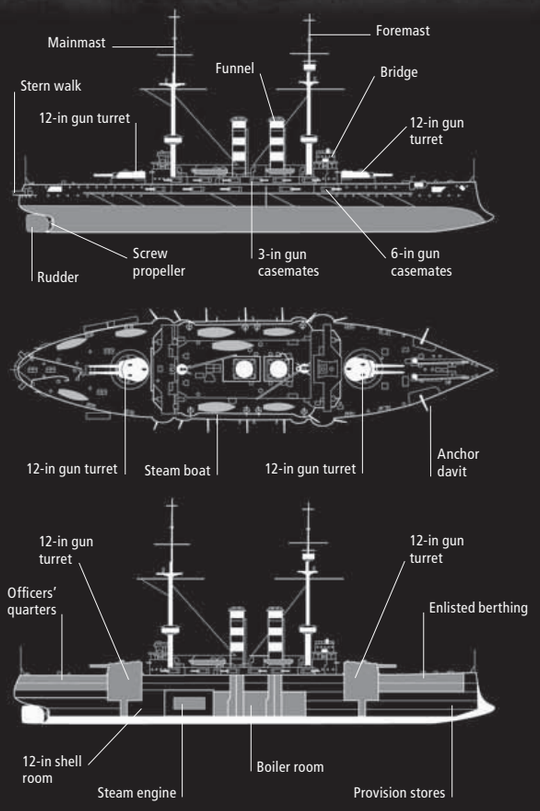
THE JAPANESE BATTLESHIP MIKASA was Admiral Togo's flagship at the decisive battle of Tsushima in 1905. She has survived to be preserved as a museum ship at Yokosuka in Japan, the only pre-dreadnought battleship still in existence. When delivered by English shipbuilders Vickers in 1902, *Mikasa* was the most advanced warship in the world.

MIKASA'S MAIN ARMAMENT consisted of four impressive 12-in guns mounted in pairs in centerline turrets. There were also 14 smaller 6-in guns arranged in broadside and 20 Quick Firing (QF) 3-in guns distributed around the ship, intended for defense against torpedo boats. The battleship also had four submerged torpedo tubes. She was heavily armored with Krupp steel plates, especially in a belt around the hull above the waterline and around the gun turrets. *Mikasa* proved capable of taking a lot of punishment. Some 30 hits from Russian guns at Tsushima failed to put her out of action. Ironically she was sunk in harbor shortly after the war with Russia ended, through an accidental explosion in a magazine. Although refloated, *Mikasa* was soon rendered obsolete as a new generation of dreadnought battleships took center stage. She was decommissioned in 1923.

Victor of Tsushima
Admiral Togo's flagship *Mikasa* pictured around 1905, the year of the Japanese victory against the Russian fleet at Tsushima. The smoke from her powerful coal-powered engines billows through the ship's funnels.



Pre-dreadnought leviathan
Constructed for the Imperial Japanese Navy at Vickers shipyard in Britain and displacing more than 15,000 tons, *Mikasa* comfortably matched the size and firepower of the Royal Navy's own leading battleships.



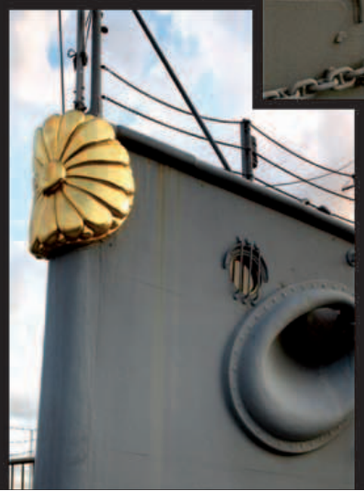


Fore anchor
The anchor rests on an indented area of the foredeck with a davit above to lift and drop it overboard. A chain runs through a hole in the bows to a capstan on the deck.

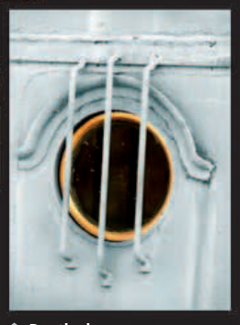


12-in gun turret
Mikasa's four main 12-in guns are grouped in pairs in two armored turrets, fore and aft, and could fire around three shells every two minutes. The power and range of *Mikasa*'s modern guns were a crucial factor at the battle of Tsushima.

Imperial crest
The gold chrysanthemum on the *Mikasa*'s bow, the emblem used on all Imperial battleships, was the seal of the emperor of Japan.



> "JAPAN BLOSSOMED FORTH LIKE HER OWN CHRYSANTHEMUM ... HER BATTLESHIPS ARE PERHAPS THE FINEST IN THE WORLD."
>
> **NAVY AND ARMY ILLUSTRATED**, BRITISH MAGAZINE, 1902



Porthole
Small portholes run along the *Mikasa*'s hull, allowing a little natural light through the thick steel of the Krupp armor plating into the decks below.